

The Morning Briefing

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LEAD STORY · WASHINGTON

Senate Confirms Blanche as Attorney General, 50-49, After Bruising Overnight Fight

The Senate confirmed Todd Blanche, President Trump's former personal criminal defense lawyer, as Attorney General in a 50-49 vote taken after 4 a.m. Saturday. Only Republicans Susan Collins of Maine and Lisa Murkowski of Alaska broke with the party to vote no, joining all Democrats. The confirmation came the same overnight session in which Senate Republicans ended a standoff over Trump's proof-of-citizenship voting bill without a vote, punting the fight to September.

U.S. POLITICS

Blanche Takes Over a Justice Department Already Facing Stacked-Up Fights

Blanche now runs a Justice Department that will oversee, among other matters, the department's posture toward litigation touching the President himself — even as Trump's personal legal team runs parallel appeals to the Supreme Court (see Judiciary, below). His confirmation followed weeks of uncertainty after Murkowski's opposition put the nomination in doubt; Sen. Bill Cassidy's late endorsement helped clear the way.

NPR npr.org/2026/08/08/g-s1-137631/senate-confirms-todd-blanche-attorney-general

Trump Won't Back Thune for Another Term, Cites GOP Voter Anger

In an unusually public break with his own party's Senate leadership, Trump declined to endorse Majority Leader John Thune for another term as the chamber's top Republican, saying GOP voters are “very angry” with congressional Republicans. The comments landed as Thune was simultaneously managing the confirmation fight and the voting-bill standoff, and they signal an intra-party rift that will shape leadership politics into the fall.

PBS NewsHour pbs.org/newshour/politics/trump-demands-senate-cancel-august-break-until-it-passes-the-save-america-act

Voting Bill Standoff Ends Without a Vote; Fight Merges With Iran War Funding in September

Senators left Washington for the August recess without passing the SAVE America Act, Trump's strict proof-of-citizenship voting bill, despite his demand that they cancel the break until it passed. Thune told colleagues the votes simply are not there to break a Democratic filibuster on the bill. Republicans instead told Trump they would try again in September — folding elements of the voting bill into a broader budget package that would also fund Iran war operations and replenish the Pentagon.

ANALYTICAL READ

Tying a domestic voting-rules fight to Iran war funding all but guarantees the two get leveraged against each other in September: Democrats gain bargaining chips over war funding, while hawkish Republicans gain leverage over the filibuster fight. Neither side has an incentive to let the other move cleanly.

Washington Times / AP [washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/8/senators-leave-town-without-meeting-trumps-demands-voting-bill](https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/8/senators-leave-town-without-meeting-trumps-demands-voting-bill)

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Trump, DOJ Ask Supreme Court to Toss \$83.3 Million Carroll Defamation Verdict

Trump and the Justice Department formally petitioned the Supreme Court to hear an appeal of the \$83.3 million defamation verdict won by E. Jean Carroll, arguing that a 2024 Supreme Court immunity ruling in Trump's favor requires the verdict to be overturned. In a related matter, the Court could act as soon as August 17 on a separate

Trump petition asking the justices to reconsider their earlier denial of review in Carroll's original \$5 million verdict.

ANALYTICAL READ

DOJ is not the defendant in Carroll's private suit — Trump's personal lawyers are handling that appeal. But the optics are still notable: the Attorney General is Trump's own former personal defense counsel, running the department at the exact moment the President's private legal fights are

working their way through the same Court. Worth watching for how it shapes perceptions of DOJ independence, even without a direct legal conflict.

SCOTUSblog scotusblog.com/2026/07/trump-asks-supreme-court-to-hear-appeal-of-83-million-defamation-verdict-against-him

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

CENTCOM Chief Visits Israel to Assess “Multi-Front Situation”

Adm. Brad Cooper, head of US Central Command, made a brief visit to Israel on August 8, meeting IDF Chief of Staff Lt. Gen. Eyal Zamir and senior officers. The IDF said the meeting “aided the countries’ close strategic relationship.” Cooper arrived from Bahrain; thousands of US troops, fighter squadrons, refueling aircraft and air-defense batteries remain deployed across the region.

Times of Israel timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/centcom-chief-visits-israel-meets-with-zamir-senior-idf-officials-report

Behind the Visit: Trump Paused the Hormuz Bombing Campaign, and Options Are Narrowing

Cooper’s Israel visit follows Trump’s late-July decision to pause a two-week US bombing campaign near Iran’s coast and the Strait of Hormuz. Cooper had advised the Pentagon and White House that available targets were largely exhausted and that continuing made little sense absent a decision to escalate to major combat operations. Trump said he paused strikes after being asked to by Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, and Iran itself, and that US-Iran talks would resume. Separately, the Pentagon has asked troops for “creative and unconventional” ideas to pressure Iran.

ANALYTICAL READ

This is an off-ramp, not a victory lap. Targets exhausted, Gulf states publicly credited with talking Trump down, and the military openly crowdsourcing workarounds because

conventional pressure is running out — none of that is the profile of a campaign heading toward decisive results. Read the CENTCOM visit as damage control and alliance management, not escalation planning.

Axios axios.com/2026/07/26/hormuz-bombing-pause-trump-iran

Hamas Presses US on Gaza Plan as Israel Warns of an “Ambush”

Hamas is pushing Washington to lean on Jerusalem over implementation of the Gaza plan, claiming it is ready to disarm under the Board of Peace roadmap. Israeli officials have reportedly warned of an “ambush,” and Israel’s government has cited “serious security concerns” about the disarmament plan, facing hardline resistance within its own governing coalition to any deal that leaves Hamas standing in any form.

ANALYTICAL READ

Treat “security concerns” here as a negotiating position, not a neutral threat assessment — Israel’s hardline coalition has an obvious interest in slow-walking a deal it never wanted, and much of this reporting traces back to anonymous Israeli officials briefing Hebrew media, which is positioning, not assessment. Washington wants this file closed so it can focus on Iran; Netanyahu’s coalition partners want it kept open. That is a genuine divergence in interest and urgency between Washington and the Israeli right, not two allies running the same play.

Times of Israel timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-08-2026

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

At Sunday Angelus, Pope Leo XIV Appeals for Sudan and Ukraine

Addressing pilgrims at his August 9 Angelus, Pope Leo XIV said: “I continue to follow with concern the tragic situation in Sudan, especially in the city of el-Obeid.” He renewed “my appeal to those in authority to guarantee humanitarian corridors for the civilian population,” and urged “the international community to support efforts aimed at bringing about an immediate ceasefire.”

Turning to Ukraine, the Pope said “tragic incidents are multiplying, causing an ever-growing number of civilian victims, including children,” and called for “international humanitarian law to be respected” and for attacks on civilian targets “to cease on both sides,” adding: “it is time to halt the spiral of violence, and make room for diplomacy and dialogue.”

EWTN News ewtnnews.com/vatican/pope-leo-xiv-appeals-for-an-end-to-violence-in-sudan-and-ukraine

Leo XIV to Return to His Order's Genazzano Shrine for September 7 Mass

Vatican News confirmed that Pope Leo XIV will return to the Shrine of Our Lady of Good Counsel in Genazzano to celebrate Mass on September 7, the eve of the Feast of the Nativity of the Blessed Virgin Mary. It is the same Augustinian shrine — entrusted to that order since 1356 — that he visited privately just two days after his 2025 election. A painting depicting him praying before the shrine’s venerated image will be unveiled; the shrine’s rector, Fr. Ludovico Centra, confirmed the plans to Vatican News. Popes Urban VIII, Pius IX, John XXIII and John Paul II are also depicted in the shrine’s chapel as prior papal visitors.

WHY IT MATTERS

Leo XIV is the first Augustinian pope in history, and this Marian shrine is bound up with his own religious order and personal devotion. The September Mass functions as a deliberate, symbolic marker of how this papacy wants to define itself heading into its second year.

WORLD NEWS

Half a Million Trapped as Siege Tightens on Sudan's El-Obeid

Roughly half a million people remain trapped in el-Obeid, the North Kordofan capital the Pope named in his Angelus appeal, as Sudan's Rapid Support Forces tighten a siege that UN human rights officials warn could produce a famine

catastrophe like the one already confirmed in el-Fasher. Drone strikes have hit water infrastructure, food prices have risen as much as 300 percent, and aid access has shrunk sharply as security conditions deteriorate.

Al Jazeera aljazeera.com/news/2026/7/6/el-obeid-under-siege-by-rsf-could-this-be-sudans-next-el-fasher

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Furious Minds: Mapping the New Right's Warring Factions

Reviewed in Reason on January 30, 2026, Furious Minds maps the New Right's competing factions — Claremonters like Michael Anton, postliberals like Patrick Deneen, and national conservatives like Yoram Hazony — and argues they are unified less by shared doctrine than by a common rejection of liberal pluralism. Useful context for reading today's Trump-Thune rift as a fight within a coalition that was never fully coherent to begin with.

Reason reason.com/2026/01/30/furious-minds

The Right-Wing Intellectuals Who Keep Winning

This Oxford Political Review essay (March 31, 2026) argues the New Right's institutional infrastructure — media outlets, conferences, academic programs — has let a small

set of writers punch far above their numbers in shaping GOP policy, and asks whether that influence outlasts Trump himself.

Oxford Political Review oxfordpoliticalreview.com/2026/03/31/the-right-wing-intellectuals-who-keep-winning

The Peculiarity of Papal Primacy

This Catholic World Report essay mounts a serious defense of the Catholic doctrine of papal primacy against both Orthodox and Protestant objections, examining how Vatican I's definition of papal authority is bounded by the Church's communio rather than functioning as an unchecked monarchy. Timely alongside today's Genazzano news, itself a small case study in how a pope uses personal devotion to project papal identity.

Catholic World Report catholicworldreport.com/2025/01/29/the-peculiarity-of-papal-primacy